
HS 559: Critical Theory and the Politics of Development

Course Code	HS 559
Course Name	Critical Theory and the Politics of Development
L-T-P-C	3-0-0-3
Prerequisites	None
Intended for	PG
Mutual Exclusion	None
Approval	60th BoA (Jun 2025)

Preamble

This course explores the intersections of critical theory and development studies, focusing on how power, ideology, and discourse shape global development practices and policies. Students will engage with theoretical frameworks and apply them to case studies, enabling them to question and reimagine development in more just and inclusive ways.

The main focus of the course will be to analyse the work of key thinkers from the Frankfurt School, poststructuralism, postcolonial theory, and decolonial thought in order to critically examine the assumptions, contradictions, and inequalities embedded in mainstream development paradigms.

The course would appeal to students interested in questioning the status quo of development and exploring transformative, justice-oriented approaches. It combines rigorous theoretical engagement with practical applications, making it both intellectually stimulating and socially relevant.

By the end of the course, students will: understand the key concepts and thinkers in critical theory and their relevance to development studies; critically analyse development policies, practices, and discourses through a critical theory lens; engage with alternative visions of development that prioritize justice, equity, and sustainability; and develop skills in interdisciplinary research, critical thinking, and transformative praxis.

Course Modules

- **Unit 1: Foundations of Critical Theory and Development:** (6 hours)
 - Introduction to critical theory (Frankfurt School, Gramsci, Foucault, etc.).
 - The historical and ideological roots of development as a project (modernity, colonialism, capitalism).
 - Critiques of Eurocentrism and the “universal” claims of development.
- **Unit 2: Power, Knowledge, and Development Discourse:** (6 hours)
 - Foucault’s concept of power/knowledge and its application to development.
 - The role of institutions (World Bank, IMF, NGOs) in shaping development agendas.
 - Deconstructing development buzzwords: “progress,” “empowerment,” “sustainability.”
- **Unit 3: Postcolonial and Decolonial Critiques of Development:** (6 hours)
 - Postcolonial theorists (e.g., Said, Spivak, Fanon) on development as a continuation of colonial power.
 - Decolonial perspectives (e.g., Quijano, Mignolo) on modernity/coloniality and alternative development imaginaries.

- The politics of representation: Who speaks for whom in development?

- **Unit 4: Capitalism, Neoliberalism, and Global Inequality:** (6 hours)

- Marxist critiques of capitalism and their relevance to development.
- Neoliberalism as a development paradigm: privatization, austerity, and structural adjustment.
- Alternatives to capitalist development: degrowth, solidarity economies, and post-development.

- **Unit 5: Gender, Race, and Intersectionality in Development:** (6 hours)

- Feminist critiques of development (e.g., Mohanty, Sen, Agarwal).
- Intersectionality and the marginalization of racialized, gendered, and indigenous voices.
- Queer theory and the heteronormativity of development policies.

- **Unit 6: Environment, Technology, and Sustainable Development:** (6 hours)

- Critical perspectives on sustainable development and the green economy.
- Techno-optimism vs. techno-skepticism: The role of technology in development.
- Environmental justice and the critique of extractivism.
- Ecocriticism, narratives of environmental degradation and conservation and the intersection of culture and sustainability.

- **Unit 7: Resistance, Social Movements, and Alternatives to Development:** (6 hours)

- Grassroots movements and counter-hegemonic practices.
- The role of art, literature, and culture in resisting dominant development narratives.
- Exploring post-development and pluriversal futures.

Primary Readings

1. Theodor Adorno & Max Horkheimer: *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (on modernity and domination).
2. Michel Foucault: *Power/Knowledge* (on discourse and power).
3. Gayatri Spivak: “Can the Subaltern Speak?” (on representation and voice).
4. Arturo Escobar: *Encountering Development* (on the invention of development).
5. Walter Dignolo: *The Darker Side of Western Modernity* (on decoloniality).
6. Vandana Shiva: “Development as a New Project of Western Patriarchy” (on ecofeminism).
7. Frantz Fanon: *The Wretched of the Earth* (on colonialism and liberation).